tone of sexual abstinence never, after all, as real in India as it is depicted to be? So far, I have known of only two kinds of reactions to the narration of such stories. The first is of Swami Dayananda, the founder of Arya Samaja and a great scholar of the Sanskrit heritage of India. In his opinion, all such references to the behavior of Indian gods and sages deserve to be burnt and destroyed. However, he does not attend to the question as to how and when they came to be written at all. But the Sanatan Dharmists will not listen to Swami Dayananda's interpretation. I think the burden lies on the traditional Hindus to try to explain and make sense of these. The other reaction with which I am familiar is that of the late Principal N. V. Thadani of Delhi, who did not regard the epics of the Purāṇas as realistic or historical accounts and tried to explain the entire and vast bulk of this literature as allegorical, and symbolically embodying the eternal truths of Indian philosophy and religion. For him, semen, incest, coitus, reckless pleasure in destroying virginity, anger, and curses do not stand for the ordinary and conventional meanings of these terms, but have quite a different and a consistent philosophical meaning with regard to religious content. Obviously none of these explanations are quite satisfactory.

INCEST

It is rather surprising, especially in contrast to the generally idealistic and highly spiritual interpretation which is so strong in India, to find that actions which are ordinarily considered in violation of all moral standards and the standards of even common decency sometimes are found in some of the more sacred text of the Indian religious tradition, and pertain to the behaviors of our ideal types of men and women. The compatibility of these practices, including the use of supernatural powers for worldly and immoral practices, seems to be somewhat commonplace and apparently accepted without any challenge, denunciation, or even moral compunction on the part of the perpetrators of these views. It is interesting to note some of these unusual and as it were inexplicable situations. They pose riddles to the serious minded and pose moral problems to those who are deeply concerned in this area of behavior.

The Vedic hymns are said to contain references to incestuous relations. Agni is said to impregnate his own mother. In the same Saṁhitā, and elsewhere, is described the incestuous relation of Prajāpati with his daughter. The twin gods Asvinas—the children of Savitṛ and Usas—married their sister Surya. Pusan loved his